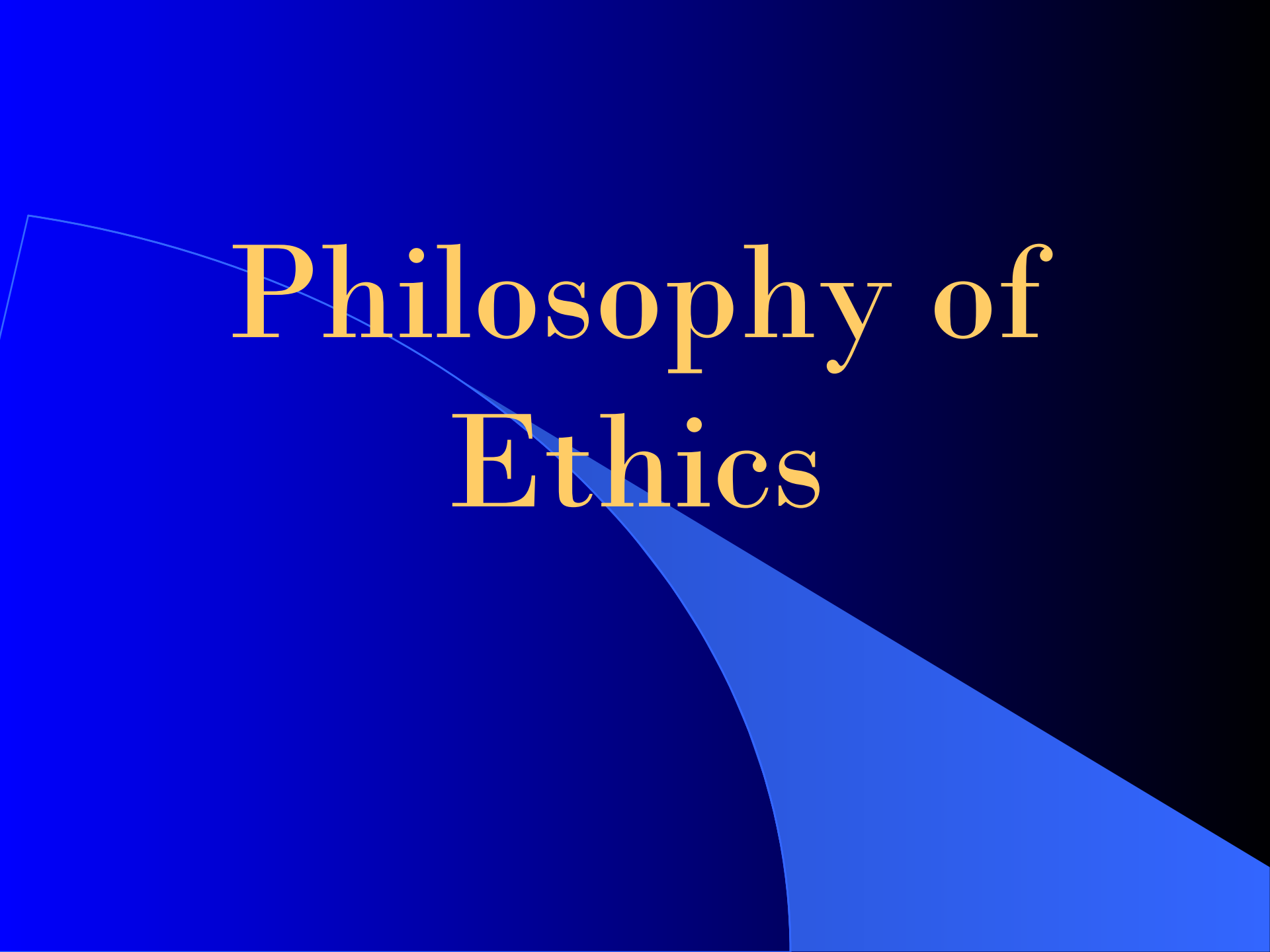




Philosophy of Ethics

A Gift of Fire

Third edition

Sara Baase

Chapter 1: Unwrapping the Gift

Slides prepared by Cyndi Chie and
Sarah Frye

Ethics

What is Ethics:

- Study of what it means to “do the right thing”
- But technology is not an immutable force, outside of human control.
- Assumes people are rational and make free choices
- Rules to follow in our interactions and our actions that affect others

Ethics

What is Ethics:

- We could view ethical rules as fundamental and universal, like laws of science.
- Or we could view them as rules we make up, like the rules of baseball, to provide a framework in which to interact with other people in a peaceful, productive way.

Ethics

What is Ethics:

- If ethical rules are good ones, they work for people.
- That is, they make our lives better.

Ethics (cont.)

Ethical Views:

- Deontological or non consequentialist
- Utilitarianism
- Natural rights
- No simple answers
 - Do organizations (businesses) have ethics?

Ethics (cont.)

Ethical Views:

- Deontological or non consequentialist
 - Deontologists tend to emphasize duty and absolute rules
 - One example is: Do not lie. An act is ethical if it complies with ethical rules and you chose it for that reason.
 - One is the principle of universality: We should follow rules of behavior that we can universally apply to everyone.

Ethics (cont.)

Ethical Views:

- Deontological or non consequentialist
 - Second, deontologists argue that logic or reason determines rules of ethical behavior, that actions are intrinsically good because they follow from logic.
 - The view that something is evil because it is illogical might seem unconvincing, but Kant's instruction to "Respect the reason in you"—that is, to use your reason, rationality, and judgment, rather than emotions, when making a decision in an ethical context—is a wise one.

Ethics (cont.)

Ethical Views:

- Deontological or non consequentialist
 - Third, Kant stated a principle about interacting with other people: One must never treat people as merely means to ends, but rather as ends in themselves.
 - if a person is looking for someone he intends to murder, and he asks you where the intended victim is, it is wrong for you to lie to protect the victim ?

Ethics (cont.)

Ethical Views:

- Deontological or non consequentialist
- Utilitarianism
 - Its guiding principle, as expressed by John Stuart Mill, is to increase happiness, or “utility.”
 - An action might decrease utility for some people and increase it for others
 - An act is right if it tends to increase aggregate utility and wrong if it tends to decrease it.

Ethics (cont.)

Ethical Views:

- Deontological or non consequentialist
- Utilitarianism
 - act utilitarianism vs rule utilitarianism
 - It might be difficult or impossible to determine all the consequences of an act.
 - How to quantify utility ?

Ethics (cont.)

A more fundamental (and ethical) objection to act utilitarianism is that it does not recognize or respect individual rights. It has no absolute prohibitions and so could allow actions that many people consider always wrong. For example, if there is a convincing case that killing one innocent person (perhaps to distribute his or her organs to several people who will die without transplants) or taking all of a person's property and redistributing it to other community members would maximize utility in a community, utilitarianism could justify these acts. A person has no protected domain of freedom.

Ethics (cont.)

Ethical Views:

- Deontological or non consequentialist
- Utilitarianism
 - Rule utilitarianism suffers far less than does act utilitarianism from these problems.
 - Recognizing that widespread killing and stealing decrease the security and happiness of all, a rule utilitarian can derive rules against these acts.
 - We can state these particular rules in terms of rights to life and property.

Ethics (cont.)

Ethical Views:

- Deontological or non consequentialist
- Utilitarianism
- Natural rights
- Contributing to society

Ethics (cont.)

Ethical Views:

- Deontological or non consequentialist
- Utilitarianism
- Natural rights
- No simple answers
 - Do organizations (businesses) have ethics?

Ethics (cont.)

Important Distinctions:

- Right, wrong and okay
 - In situations with ethical dilemmas, there are often many options that are ethically acceptable, with no specific one ethically required
 - Rather, it is better to think of acts as either ethically obligatory, ethically prohibited, or ethically acceptable.
 - Many actions might be virtuous and desirable but not obligatory

Ethics (cont.)

Important Distinctions (cont.):

- Difference between wrong and harm
 - Harm alone is not enough to conclude
- Separating goals from constraints
- Personal preference and ethics
- Law and Ethics

Ethics

Discussion Question

- Can you think of examples of liberties (negative rights) and claim-rights (positive rights) that are at opposition to each other?